

cryptocurrencies through the Zionverse platform. And an art event was hosted on the NextMeet platform by Broward College, Florida, USA.

Second Life platform has introduced a metaverse social platform for making new friends and interacting with them. LokaLocal has introduced virtual touring through a metaverse world that has 3D real-world images of cities and places.

The metaverse has been conceptualised by various platforms for training, education and virtual collaboration, healthcare, banking, financial services and retail sectors for an improved customer experience and to spread the reach of businesses.

The different stages of maturity of metaverse platforms

Metaverse promises to be a disruptive technology over the next five years across many sectors. Its early adoption is envisaged in home office and collaborative platforms, and in virtual training and education services. As per Gartner, the different maturity stages of metaverse are:

- Technology using Web3, head-mounted devices, and use cases like virtual shopping — this is the ‘emerging metaverse’ which we are experiencing currently.
- Technology developed for digital experience platforms (DXP), multi-modal interfaces and immersive experience systems — this is the ‘advanced metaverse’, a stage we can expect to reach by 2025.
- Technology that is interoperable using digital currency, blockchain, security and compliance for the crypto economy (and uses spatial data) will be part of the ‘mature metaverse’, a stage that will be reached by 2029.

The future

The metaverse promises to evolve into something very similar to our real

world, and may even replace some real-world activities.

A few metaverse non-fungible token (NFT) vendors have enabled their NFTs to be used on some metaverse games for clothing and footwear; others are planning to do so. An increasing number of NFT enthusiasts are also sensing opportunities to invest in virtual lands on such games, and sell or rent them for a price. The metaverse can be a huge contributing factor to the growth of the virtual economy, which depends on video games and virtual worlds.

If NFTs are incorporated as in-game assets, decentralisation of the virtual economy can become a reality. Today, we already have a nascent version of the metaverse with NFTs representing popular art and digital memorabilia being lapped up by investors and crypto fans alike.

With major players like Meta entering this space and confidently signalling a great future for it, it is only a matter of time before others follow suit. This could lead to an exponential expansion of the boundaries of the metaverse and unlock vast volumes of value hitherto unknown to consumers and investors alike.

The future of the metaverse also rides on the idea of it running openly, almost without any interruption from a single community or company, with brands from across the world opening their outlets on it, just like they have done on the internet today.

The Top 12 metaverse platforms

In our opinion, the following are the top 12 metaverse platforms today.

Altspace VR: Acquired in 2017 by Microsoft, this virtual platform enables the creation of virtual events and is part of the tech giant’s mixed reality division. Users can host a meetup, a show or a class.

BlueJeans: BlueJeans from Verizon is a video platform designed to optimise flexible work in enterprises and mid-sized businesses. In 2021, the company partnered with MootUp to reimagine “virtual events in the era of the metaverse with 3D, VR and AR immersive environments, avatars and AI chatbots.”

Cryptovoxels: Cryptovoxels is a virtual world gaming platform powered by crypto and the Ethereum blockchain. It includes real-life infrastructure such as roads and buildings.

Gather: Gather is focused on video chat that builds a virtual layer over the physical world. It is an enterprise-specific offering that mimics an office construct and deeply integrates with video conferencing.

Metahero: Metahero, from Web 3 company Pixel Vault, is a universe where anyone can be a hero. The platform offers six different kits with avatars that can be customised and personalised.

Meta Horizon Worlds and Horizon Workrooms: Meta (formerly Facebook) bills its fledgling metaverse Horizon platform as an “ever-expanding social universe” to hang out with friends and create your own worlds. Workrooms is the company’s mixed reality app for employee collaboration.

Nvidia Omniverse: The chipmaker’s virtual platform focuses on 3D design work on computer graphics, simulations and the creation of new worlds.

Roblox: Roblox’s vision is to give people a platform that empowers them to create their own experiences. “Our vision is to reimagine the way people come together to create, play, explore, learn and connect with one another.”

Room: Room specialises in enterprise virtual showrooms, 3D product presentations and virtual events that can be used by marketing and sales groups in verticals such as education, retail, life sciences and manufacturing.

Sandbox: Sandbox is a community-driven gaming platform built on the